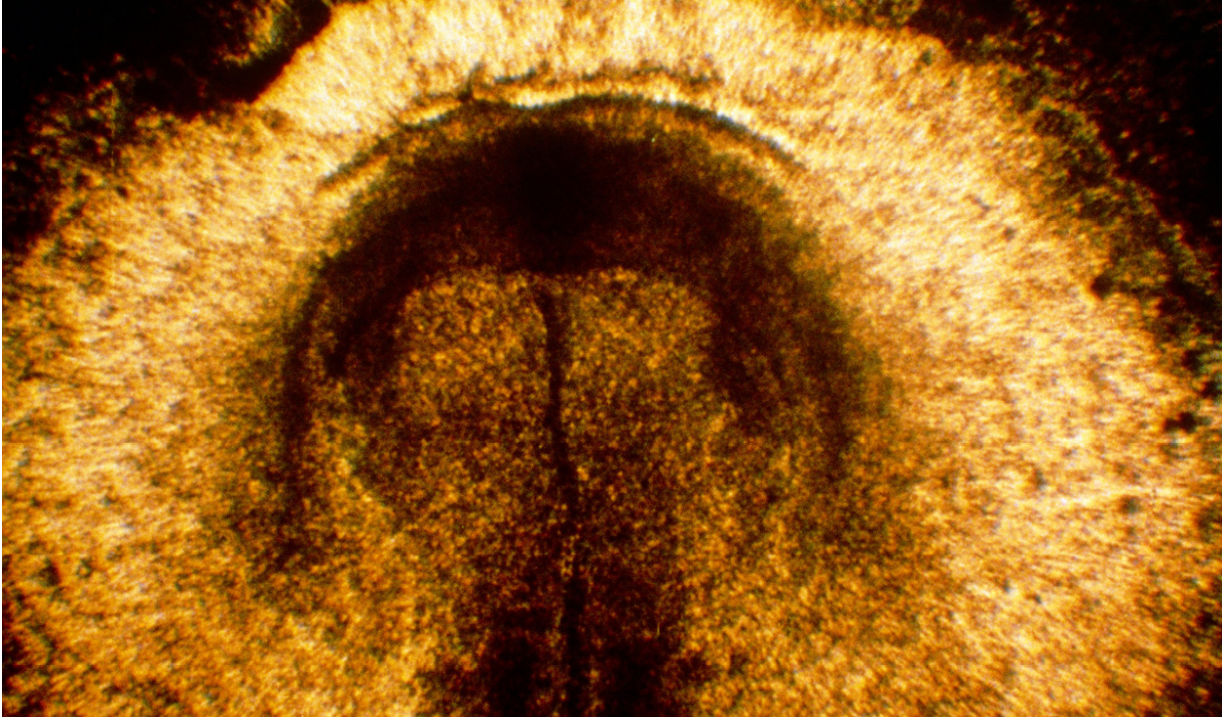




Shown here is the **neural tube of an embryo** in the early stages of pregnancy. The brain and spinal cord will develop from the neural tube. If the tube does not fully close, it can lead to birth defects, most commonly spina bifida.

ASK A DOCTOR

I've been having difficulty getting pregnant and have now been diagnosed with polycystic ovary syndrome. What is this? This condition causes the ovaries to be bigger than normal and they produce a large number of small follicles that never grow to full maturity. Therefore an egg is not released to be fertilized and periods are very irregular.

The condition is a common cause of fertility problems. Treatments are aimed at stimulating ovulation and reducing some of the symptoms such as increased body hair and acne. Polycystic ovary syndrome appears to run in families.

FOCUS ON RELATIONSHIPS

It's the positive result you've been waiting for—hopefully!—but how do you share it with your partner? You could present them with an envelope containing your positive pregnancy test, or explain that you have a “special gift” but it won't be ready until about, oh, nine months. It shouldn't take them long to figure it out! Ideally, choose a time when you are both alone and feeling relaxed so that it can be a special moment. You may want to do another test with your partner just to make sure and also so that they feel involved.

Even if you're excited, and even if you can't get in touch with your partner for a day, don't be tempted to tell your mom and close friends first. Your partner may be upset if others know they're going to be a parent before they do.